

Other and the Decomposition of Romance Pronominal Possessives

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1. Introduction.

First and second person plural possessives in Romance begin with *n-* and *v-*,¹ respectively, and, apart from the final agreement vowel, end in *-tr-*, as in Italian *nostro* ('our'), *vostro* ('your-pl'). A familiar question arises as to how many morphemes we are looking at and what their properties are. In this paper, I will primarily try to show that *-tr-* is a separate morpheme and to say something about its properties.

2. *n-*, *v-* and *-s*

The Italian possessive pair *nostro/vostro*, the parallel Spanish pair *nuestro/vuestro* and the parallel French pair *notre/votre* strongly suggest that *n-* and *v-* are distinct morphemes associated with first and second person plural, respectively. In Spanish this gives us *n+uestro*, *v+uestro*, in examples such as:

- (1) *nuestro* libro ('our book')
- (2) *vuestro* libro ('your(pl.) book')

The *n-* of (1) is also found in the corresponding Spanish object clitic *nos* ('us') and in the non-clitic *nosotros* ('we/us+others' = 'we/us'). The 2pl. *v-* of (2) is likewise found in non-clitic *vosotros* ('you-pl+others' = 'you-pl.'), though it is not seen (it may well be deleted) in object clitic *os* ('you-pl.').² The Spanish object clitics *nos* and *os* end, moreover, in an *-s* that is plausibly taken to be the Spanish general plural *-s*.³ If so, we have, for *nos*:

- (3) *n+o+s*

3. Decomposition.

The syntactic status of *-o-* in (3) is not entirely clear, so that one might perhaps think of the decomposition 'no+s'. For what follows in this paper, the choice between 'n+o+s' and 'no+s' will not matter much. I think, though, that (3) is in fact the correct choice, in part because the vowel of 2pl. *os* is the same as the vowel of 1pl. *nos*, and similarly for *nosotros/vosotros* and for *nuestro/vuestro*. If we had 'no+s' for 1pl., we would have 'vo+s' for 2pl., with the identity of the two instances of *-o-* then being accidental (and similarly for the diphthong *-ue*).

¹The form *vuestro* (along with related forms such as *vosotros*) is generally absent from Latin American Spanish in a way that is not specific to possessives; for further discussion, see section 19.

²That *os* has a silent counterpart of *v-* is suggested by the fact that *os* is not found in Latin America, as noted by Butt and Benjamin (1994, sect. 11.7.1).

³Cf. Harris (1997, 39). Notable are Spanish dialects in which the *-s* can be separated from *no-* by another object clitic, with 'no lo s' in place of the expected 'nos lo' - cf. Harris and Halle (2005, 196).

Additional evidence for (3) comes from French, where the vowel of (3) varies, but always in the same way for 1pl and 2pl. The vowel in non-possessive clitic and in non-clitic is /u/, as in 1pl. *nous* and 2pl. *vous*. The vowel is /o/ in both possessive plural *nos* and in possessive plural *vos*; a longer version of that vowel is found both in possessive *nôtre* and in possessive *vôtre* (forms that occur when the associated noun is deleted/silent). Finally, the vowel is /ɔ/ both in possessive *notre* and in possessive *votre*. Even without attempting to account for the details of these vowel alternations, it seems clear that for French we must have:

(4) n+V+s; v+V+s; n+V+tre; v+V+tre
with V indicating the appropriate vowel, whatever its status. (It is likely, too, that the *-tre* forms in (4) contain a silent/deleted *-s-* corresponding to the pronounced *-s-* of Spanish *nos, nuestro....*)

4. More on decomposition.

Of the forms so far discussed, the ones with the most pronounced relevant segments are Spanish possessive *nuestro/vuestro* and Italian possessive *nostro/vostro*. By the preceding reasoning, Spanish calls for the following decomposition, and similarly for Italian:

(5) n/v+ue+s+tr+o (Spanish)

(6) n/v+o+s+tr+o (Italian)

where *n-/v-* corresponds to the person of the possessor, *-ue/-o-* to the vowel in question,⁴ *-s-* to the plural number of the possessor, and *-o* to the morpheme that reflects the gender of the possessed noun.⁵ That leaves us with the question of *-tr-* that is more central to this paper.

Before proceeding to that question, let us note in passing that although Spanish and Italian have in common in (5)/(6) both *-tr-* and *-s-*, a question arises for this Italian *-s-* that does not arise for Spanish, insofar as the Italian non-clitic 1pl. and 2pl. forms fail to show an *-s-*:

(7) *noi* ('we/us'); *voi* ('you-pl.')

The *-i* of (7) is almost certainly the usual plural *-i* of Italian masculine plurals such as *ragazzi* ('boys'), of certain feminine plurals such as *reti* ('networks'), and of masculine and some feminine adjectives. This Italian plural *-i* generally requires (unlike Spanish *-s*) that the final vowel of the singular not be pronounced, i.e. Italian has *ragazzo* ('boy'), *ragazzi* ('boys'), but not **ragazzo-i*.⁶

The Italian possessive forms are, however:

(8) *nostro* ('our'); *vostro* ('your (pl.)')

These have *-s-*, as in Spanish, and cannot have the *-i-* of (7):

⁴On the diphthongization, v. Harris (1969). To be noted is the fact that in the plural possessive, in both Spanish and Italian, this vowel or diphthong is the same for first and second person, as opposed to the singular possessive contrast *mi-* ('my') vs. *tu-* ('your (sg.)'), where the vowels differ.

⁵Harris (1991) takes this final vowel to be a W(ord)M(arker) in Spanish; extension to Italian would be straightforward.

⁶A possible exception is plural *-i* in possessive plural-agreeing *tuoi* ('your (sg.)'), *suoi* ('his/her'), in a way that seems to depend on stress falling on the *-o-*.

(9) *noitro; *voitro

It is highly likely, though, that (9) is excluded on purely phonological grounds, since Italian, as far as I can see, has no words of any type that end in *-oitroV*, for any vowel V.

Conversely, it may be that the contrast within Italian between the legitimate *-s-* of (8) and the impossibility of *-s* in:

(10) *nos; *vos (Italian)

could fall under a phonological generalization to the effect that Italian generally disallows word-final *-s*. If so, the *-s* of (8) is a plural morpheme just like the *-s* of Spanish (5), with the much wider distribution of plural *-s* in Spanish then attributable to a phonological difference between Spanish and Italian.

5. A decompositionality principle.

Before turning to *-tr-* itself, let us note in further passing that the fact that (5), (6) and (8) should have for the possessor a separate plural morpheme *-s* (and similarly for the *-i* of (7)) accompanying the person morphemes *n-/v-* reflects the decompositionality principle suggested in Kayne (2005a, Appendix), to the effect that:⁷

(11) UG imposes a maximum of one (interpretable) syntactic feature per lexical item. This principle has as a consequence that a person morpheme such as *n-* or *v-* cannot simultaneously contain a number feature, which must (if one is necessary, as in the plural, at least) be associated with a separate morpheme (Spanish *-s*, Italian *-i*, Italian *-s*).

Decompositionality as in (11) may also be of help in understanding certain facts concerning singular possessives, examples of which in, say, Italian are:⁸

(12) mio ('my'); tuo ('your (sg.)'); suo ('his/her')

Like the plural possessives, these contain an initial person morpheme and a final agreement morpheme.⁹ Therefore we have the decomposition:

(13) m+i+o; t+u+o; s+u+o

The intervening vocalic morpheme *-i-*, *-u-* in (13) has a status that I will return to briefly.¹⁰ For the time being, let us focus on the fact that (12)/(13) has the notable property that there is no counterpart with 1pl. *n-* or with 2pl. *v-*, whether with *-i-* or with *-u-*:

(14) *nio; *nuo; *vio; *vuo

⁷Note that lexical items/items in the lexicon will always be monomorphemic if multimorphemic words are invariably composed in the syntax by Merge, an idea that goes back in one specific case to Chomsky's (1957) affix-hopping; cf. more generally Baker (1988), Halle & Marantz (1993) and Collins & Kayne (2023).

⁸In a way that is not important to the text argument, the *s-* of *suo* is not, strictly speaking, a third person morpheme; for recent discussion, see Kayne (2018). The differences in Italian between pre-N *mio* and post-N *mio* discussed by Cardinaletti (1998) might be related to Barbaud (1976) on pre-V vs. post-V focus in French.

⁹Corresponding to Italian *tuo*, *suo*, Spanish has *tuyo*, *suyo*. Whether this *-y-* is a separate morpheme, or just phonological, is left an open question.

¹⁰It seems almost certain that this vowel is a separate morpheme in these forms, in both Spanish and Italian, rather than being part of the person morpheme. (This is especially clear for *su-*, insofar as *-u-* is found with *s-* only in possessives.)

As far as I know, the contrast between (12) and (14) holds across all of Romance.

If (14) were possible, the pronominal possessive paradigm would look more regular. Why is that regularity out of reach? Of likely importance is the fact that Decompositionality, as in (11), requires that the plurality that would be associated with *n-*, *v-* in (14) would have to be expressed by a separate plural morpheme, which in (14) is visibly lacking.¹¹ (This suggests that (12)/(13) do not need to be associated explicitly with singularity).

6. *-i-* and *-u-*

The next question is then whether we could add *-s-* to (14), in any Romance language. As far as I know, the answer is no, as seen in the apparent cross-Romance impossibility of the following possessives:

(15) **niso*; **nuso*; **viso*; **vuso*

Possibly, this restriction on plural *-s-* could be related to one generally found in English deverbal compounds, as in:¹²

(16) John is an avid newspaper(*s)-reader.

(17) Can you see that newspaper(*s)-reading linguist over there?

As for the exact status of the *-i-/u-* morpheme in (12)/(13), it might perhaps be a possessive or Case morpheme having something in common with English 's, with the twist that *-i-* would appear to select for first person singular and *-u-* not. In addition, this *-i-* and *-u-* seen in *mio*, *tuo*, *suo* arguably has something in common with the English trio *here*, *there*, *where*. This is so insofar as *there* rhymes with *where*, but *here*, despite the common orthography, does not. The 'odd man out' status of *here*, relative to *there*, *where* is akin to that of *mio* relative to *tuo*, *suo*, especially in that both *here* and *mio* are (related to) first person.¹³

7. *-tr-* and *other*

We can now come back to the question of the status of the *-tr-* seen in first and second person plural possessive forms, as in Italian *nostro*, *vostro*, Spanish *nuestro*, *vuestro*, and French *notre*, *votre*, as discussed above. A proposal that immediately comes to mind is that the *-tr-* of these possessive forms is the same *-tr-* that is found in non-possessive forms such as Spanish non-clitic:

(18) *nosotros*

as in:

(19) Juan habla de nosotros. ('J speaks of us-others')

¹¹As it is in the Paduan 1st person plural object clitic *ne*. Either this *ne* must be accompanied by a silent plural morpheme that would not be available to possessive **ni(o)*, or else this Paduan *ne* is, more likely, to be treated as Kayne (2009) did Italian *ci*, with *ci* able in Italian to license a silent 1pl. object clitic (in a way that should perhaps be extended to Italian *vi*).

¹²Which to my ear is even sharper if the compound itself is made plural:

i) They're both avid newspaper(**s)-readers.

ii) Can you see those newspaper(**s)-reading linguists over there.

This recalls facts discussed in Zwicky (1969) and Kimball and Aissen (1971).

¹³Cf. Kayne (2010a) and Noonan (2017).

whose ordinary French and Italian counterparts are:

(20) Jean parle de nous.

(21) Gianni parla di noi.

with Spanish having the distinctive property that *otros* in (19) is obligatory:

(22) *Juan habla de nos.

Setting aside the question of how best to enforce that obligatoriness, we can readily see that Spanish *nosotros* is composed of *nos* + *otros*. Adding a counterpart of *otros* is possible, but not obligatory, in French and Italian:

(23) Jean parle de nous autres.

(24) Gianni parla di noi altri.

The decomposition of *nosotros* into *nos*+*otros* has the advantage of allowing us to maintain the generalization that Romance languages (like Germanic and Slavic languages) do not show any grammatical gender distinction in the form of their first or second person pronouns, examples being:

(25) yo; *ya (Spanish 'I')

(26) io; *ia (Italian - same)

That is, there is no alternation in the first and second person pronouns of the -o vs. -a sort that is otherwise widespread in both Italian and Spanish.

Relevant now is:

(27) nosotros; nosotras

Here we do have -os vs. -as, but the decomposition *nos*+*otros/otras* allows us to say that the gender distinction in (27) involves just *otros/otras*;¹⁴ the form of *nos* remains constant in (27) and does not itself vary in gender. The feminine -a- in *nosotras* is not part of the pronoun proper, which is *nos*, but rather part of non-pronominal *otras*.¹⁵ (Adjectival or participial agreement in gender with a first or second person pronoun is often visibly possible in Romance.)

8. French

Taking -tr- in Italian *nostro*, Spanish *nuestro* and French *notre* to be morphemically separate from the preceding pronominal *nos-*, *nues-*, *no-* is also relevant to the question of the parallelism between sentential clitics and possessives discussed in Kayne (1975, sect. 2.20) and Cardinaletti (1998), both of whom took the 'whole' possessive to be clitic-like. For example in French *mon frère*, it is (for both of them) *mon* that is parallel to object clitic *me*. Extended to first plural, *notre* is then parallel to *nous*, with this parallelism illustrated in the following, with regard to a particular subtype of quantifier-stranding:

(28) C'est notre ami à tous. ('it is our friend to all' = 'He's the friend of all of us')

(29) Il nous a parlé à tous. ('he us has spoken to all' = 'He's spoken to all of us')

From the present perspective, this parallelism remains real, though now we see that it holds despite the presence of -tr- in (28) vs. its absence in (29); that absence is necessary:

(30) *Il notre a parlé à tous.

¹⁴This differs from Dobrovie-Sorin and Giurgea (2011, 134).

¹⁵Cf. Kayne (2003, note 28).

The parallelism in question carries over in French to singular possessives, illustrated here with a certain type of doubling:

(31) C'est mon ami à moi. ('it is my friend to me')

(32) Il m'a parlé à moi. ('he me has spoken to me')

Again there is a discrepancy in form between *mon* and *m'*, and again, just like (30) we have:

(33) *Il mon a parlé à moi.

Of potential interest to the similar unacceptability of *-tr-* in (30) and of *-on* in (33) is the fact that, although they are not entirely parallel, *-on* and *-tr-* share the property in French that they both 'disappear' (i.e. are deleted) in the plural, as seen for *-tr-* in:

(34) nos amies ('our friends(fem.))

(35) *notres amies

and for *-on* in:

(36) mes livres ('my books')

(37) *mons livres

French possessive *-on* is also deleted in the feminine singular if the following word begins with a pronounced consonant.¹⁶ Alongside the masculine singular:

(38) mon frère ('my brother')

one might have expected:

(39) *mon(n)e soeur

whereas one has in fact, without *-on*:

(40) ma soeur ('my sister')

In (40) *ma* is clearly decomposable as *m+a*, with *m-* the usual 1sg. morpheme and *-a* the same feminine singular *-a* seen in the fem.sg. definite article *la*.

Of interest now is the fact that *la* can function as a third person object clitic.¹⁷

(41) Je la vois. ('I her/it see')

contrary to *ma*:

(42) *Elle ma voit. ('she *ma* sees')

a plausible account of which is that by virtue of containing *-ON*, a silent counterpart of possessive *-on*, *ma* is, in (42), in a way that needs to be made more precise,¹⁸ too complex to be an object clitic (and that should carry over to (30) and (33)). The same holds for the plural possessive *mes* of (36), which despite being similar in form to the plural definite article *les*, contrasts sharply with it:

(43) Je les vois. ('I them see')

(44) *Ils mes voient. ('they *mes* see')

Again, the reason is very likely that *mes*, by virtue of containing silent possessive *-ON*, is too complex to be an object clitic.

Similar to the impossibility of *mes* as object clitic is that of plural demonstrative *ces*:

(45) *Je ces vois. ('I these/those see')

¹⁶Whether or not there needs to be a silent possessive morpheme in *notre*, *votre* (and similarly for other Romance) is not entirely clear.

¹⁷Cf. Postal (1966).

¹⁸In particular, the inadmissible complexity of 'm-ON-a' as an object clitic needs to be reconciled with the admissible complexity associated with French *en* in Kayne and Pollock (to appear) and with French (remnant) *y* in Kayne (2008).

which carries over to masculine singular demonstrative *ce*, despite the similarity of *ce* to the masculine singular definite article *le*:

(46) **Je ce vois.*

(47) *Je le vois.* ('I him/it see')

The silent element that prevents *ces* and *ce* from being object clitics is probably a silent counterpart of the *-t-* that appears in the masc.sg. if the following word begins with a vowel:¹⁹

(48) *cet arbre* ('this/that tree')

and in the fem.sg.:

(49) *cette table* ('this/that table')

9. More on *-tr-*.

Returning to Spanish, we have the well-known contrast:

(50) *su casa*

(51) *nuestra casa*

Possessive *mi-*, *tu-*, *su-*, when prenominal,²⁰ show no gender agreement,²¹ as opposed to *nuestr-*, *vuestr-*. From the present perspective this fact could be stated as:

(52) Spanish pre-N possessives can show gender agreement (alternatively, a WordMarker) only if *-tr-* is present.

Or even better as:

(53) The gender agreement (or WM) seen in Spanish pre-N possessives is a property of *-tr-*.

with this agreement taken to be identical to that found in:

(54) *otra casa* ('other house')

and to reflect our earlier proposal that the *-tr-* of *nuestro/a*, *vuestro/a* is the *-tr-* of *otro/a*.

Additional support for this proposal concerning *-tr-* comes from a comparison between 1st/2nd person and 3rd person. Third person pronouns in Spanish contain an *l*. Yet alongside *nuestr-* and *vuestr-* there is no **luestr-*:

(55) **luestra casa*

as if *-tr-*, while compatible with *n-* and *v-*, is not compatible with *l-*. But that is exactly what we find in Italian,²² too, in the Italian counterparts of Spanish *nosotros*, *vosotros*:

(56) *noialtri* ('we/us others')

(57) *voialtri* ('you-pl others')

(58) **loroaltri* ('they/them other')

¹⁹For relevant discussion, cf. Leu (2007; 2015). It is also possible that *ces* is associated with a silent LE, as in Kayne and Pollock (to appear).

²⁰Prenominal possessors are found in standard Spanish only in definite DPs; for recent discussion of indefinite DPs with possessors, see Eguren and Roca (2025).

²¹And/or show no word marker in Harris's (1991) sense. Why exactly this holds I leave an open question, keeping in mind that Spanish *sus casas* vs. *las casas suyas* recalls in part Greenberg's (1966) Universal 33 ("When number agreement between the noun and verb is suspended and the rule is based on order, the case is always one in which the verb precedes and the verb is in the singular").

²²Guglielmo Cinque (p.c.).

Thus, taking the *-tr-* of *nuestr-*, *vuestr-* to be the *-tr-* of *otro/a* allows us to unify (55) and (58).

Like Italian here is standard colloquial French:²³

(59) nous autres ('we/us others')

(60) vous autres ('you-pl others')

(61) *eux autres ('they/them - masc. others')

(62) *elles autres ('they/them - fem. others')

The contrast between (51) and (55) is arguably paralleled in Spanish by that between:

(63) nosotros ('we/us others')

and the following:

(64) *losotros, *ellosotros ('they/them - masc. others')

(65) *lasotras, *ellasotras ('they/them - fem. others')

Nosotros is how Spanish expresses ordinary *we* or *us* in non-clitic position. If any of the third person forms in (64)/(65) were possible in exactly the same way, they would correspond to ordinary *they* or *them* in non-clitic position, with no obvious interpretive contribution from *otros/otras*, but it seems that that cannot be the case.

10. English

In (my) English, there exists person sensitivity of the sort just discussed:²⁴

(66) We linguists are evidently in agreement with one another.

(67) You linguists are evidently in agreement with one another.

(68) *They linguists are evidently in agreement with one another.

There may be a connection to my partial (non-standard) acceptance of:

(69) ?Us here linguists are the best.

insofar as (69) suggests, whatever its exact degree of acceptability, that we should take *we linguists* and *you linguists* to be as in:

(70) we HERE linguists

(71) you THERE linguists

with a silent demonstrative reinforcer.²⁵

Now overt reinforcers have, in my non-standard English, the following property:

(72) this here chair

(73) these here chairs

²³For reasons that need to be elucidated, there are varieties of French that allow *eux autres*, as pointed out by Grevisse and Goosse (2011, sect. 358a1). These varieties include that of Jean-Yves Pollock (p.c.), who accepts *eux autres* (though not **elles autres*).

²⁴Delorme & Dougherty (1972, note 5) call *They men are here* "quite peculiar".

Cf. also:

i) I need a pick-me-up.

ii) *He needs a pick-him-up.

with a likely link in turn to:

iii) I just met another Brooklyn-/the Bronx-loving linguist.

For relevant discussion, see Kayne (2024a).

²⁵Of the sort discussed by Bernstein (1997).

- (74) that there chair
 (75) *those there chairs
 with (75) giving way to:
 (76) them there chairs

in which *them* is arguably demonstrative, just like *these*, *that*, *this*. The preceding facts suggest in turn that the deviance of (68) could be understood as closely related to that of (75), even if the underlying common reason is not immediately clear.

As a final point about English, consider the fact that there is no singular counterpart to *we/us/you/them linguists*,²⁶ as we can see in:

- (77) *I linguist can't agree with that.
 (78) *You linguist (evidently) can't agree with that.
 (79) *He/*She linguist can't agree with that.

This singular vs. plural contrast can be attributed to the HERE and THERE of (70), (71) if we say that those silent elements are available only in a plural context.

Of note now is the fact that a comparable restriction to plural contexts is found elsewhere with demonstratives, in much English (including mine), in which there is a sharp distinction of the following sort:

- (80) Those linguists are more interested in phonology than these are.
 (81) *That linguist is more interested in phonology than this is.

The noun (or NP) associated with *these* (and similarly for *those*) is, in a recoverable fashion, deletable in a way that the noun (or NP) associated with *this* (and similarly for *that*) is not.

Why exactly plural facilitates deletion in these cases remains to be understood, but the similarity between the pair (80)/(81) and the HERE/THERE facts of (77)–(79) surely increases the plausibility of the very postulation of HERE/THERE.²⁷

Example (81) involves an animate noun *linguist*. With inanimates, English does allow sentences such as:

- (82) Your house is impressive, but I wouldn't like to live in that myself.
 But I don't think that this kind of example fully matches the antecedent-based deletion of (80). Rather, (82) feels very much like:

- (83) Your house is impressive, but I wouldn't like to live in that thing myself.
 which leads me to think that the deleted/silent noun in (82) is not HOUSE, but THING. Somewhat similarly, we have:

- (84) John left early. That's too bad.
 again with THING or perhaps FACT. (Why exactly this kind of silent element acts differently from the one in (81) remains to be understood.)

11. The *o-* of *otro*.

Taking the *-tr-* of Spanish *nuestro*, *vuestro* to be the same as the *-tr-* of *otro*, and in particular to be very much like the *-tr-* of *nosotros*, *vosotros*, as I have been doing, leads

²⁶As discussed by Delorme and Dougherty (1972).

²⁷Whether this HERE/THERE hypothesis is extendable to Romance languages is left an open question.

to further questions. One has to do with the fact that the initial *o-* of *otro*, which appears in *nosotros*, *vosotros*, cannot appear in their possessive counterparts:²⁸

(85) *nues(*o)tro* libro

(86) **nosotro* libro

and similarly for Italian *al-* (which does appear in *noialtri*, *voialtri* - v. (56)/(57)):

(87) *il nos(*al)tro* libro

(88) **il noialtro* libro

Since it seems highly unlikely that any purely phonological account of all of (85)-(88) will make itself available, I will instead interpret (85)-(88) as indicating that the *o-* of Spanish *otro* and the *al-* of Italian *altro* are in fact separate morphemes distinct from *-tr+o*.

This separation is, I think, supported by English *else*,²⁹ whose *el-* arguably matches Italian *al-*, as well as by French *ailleurs* ('elsewhere'), whose initial *aill-* also arguably does (especially thinking of the alternation seen in French *aller* ('to go') vs. *aille* ('go - subjunctive')).

My guess is that an understanding of the facts of (85)-(88) will now rest on an understanding of the interpretive contribution of each postulated subpart of *o+tro* and *al+tro*. Relevant, I think, is Ernout and Thomas (1972, 199) on Latin counterparts of *other*: "*Alius*...lorsqu'il s'agit de plusieurs; *alter*...lorsqu'il s'agit de *deux*", saying in effect that (at a certain stage in the history of Latin) *alius* vs. *alter* reflected a plural vs. dual distinction, with dual indicated by the suffix *-ter(o)*, as indicated also by Weiss (2009, 285, 356).

I would like to interpret these clues from Latin as follows. English *other*, Spanish *otro* and Italian *altro* are, as in Culicover and Jackendoff's (2005, chap. 11) discussion of *el/so*, obviative. But the Latin facts just mentioned, taken together with Decompositionality as in (11), suggest that this core obviative interpretation resides solely in the initial morpheme *o-* (English, Spanish) or *al-* (Italian).

The second morpheme, *-ther* in English or *-tr* in Spanish and Italian, will then have nothing to do with obviative. It may, though, still have something to do with dual, especially if there's a link in (my) English to *either*, *neither*, which show dualness in:

(89) You can have either/neither of those two/*three books.

There may, moreover, be a broader sense in which *other* is dual, despite the overall phrase *the others* not being so, if we think of the comparative side of *other*, as in:

(90) John is other than he seems.

(91) We have other friends than just John.

combined with the fact that comparative structures are in general dual, in a certain sense. Although one can readily have three-way (or more) comparisons, as in:

(92) I'd like you to compare those three students with one another.

the result cannot be expressed as:

²⁸Conversely, non-possessive non-clitic *nosotros* cannot be replaced by **nostros* or by **nuestros*, for reasons to be determined.

²⁹How closely the following restriction is related to the ones under discussion is not clear:

i) He's a real nobody (*else).

and similarly for:

ii) He's really changed/*othered in the past year.

(93) *Susan is taller than Bill than Ann.

Returning to the main point of this section, namely (85)-(88), we can now see that pronominal possessives such as *nuestro* are prohibited from containing as an internal subpart the obviative morpheme *o-/a/-* of *otro/altro*. The question is why. Culicover and Jackendoff (2005, chap. 11) emphasize the relation between obviative and referential dependency. Since pronouns play a prominent role in referential dependency, it becomes tempting to think that the impossibility of obviative *o-/a/-* in (85)-(88) is, in a way that will need to be made precise, related to the impossibility of (third person) pronouns in sentences like:³⁰

(94) *Nixon would have liked to be able to disregard all those him-haters.

(95) *Nixon would have liked to be able to disregard all those him-hating linguists.

Also:

(96) That's a very Austenian novel.

but not:

(97) *Jane Austen would not have considered that to be very her-ian.

As for an account of (94)-(97), and perhaps by extension (85)-(88), we might look to the proposal in Kayne (2002) according to which a pronoun-antecedent relation must be mediated by internal merge, with the antecedent moving out of a 'big DP' that contains both the pronoun and the antecedent. If so, then the ill-formedness of (94), (95) and (97) would reduce to the impossibility of having movement take place out from within constituents of the *-er*, *-ing* and *-ian* sort in question, e.g.:

(98) *Austen that's a very -ian novel.

as well as:

(99) *Nixon there were lots of -haters back then.

12. A restriction on agreement.

When, in non-possessive contexts *o-* is present, then *o+tr* agrees in familiar fashion:

(100) *nosotras* ('us others(fem.)')

(101) *otras casas* ('other(fem.) houses')

In (100), the *-as* reflects agreement with an entirely female 1pl. *nos-*. But when the *o-* of *otr-* is absent as in the possessives under consideration,³¹ *-tr-* cannot agree with the first (or second) person possessor pronoun, contrary to what we see in (100):

(102) *nuestro libro* ('our book')

(103) **nuestras libro*

(104) **nuestraso libro*

In (102), in which *-tr-* is not preceded by *o-*, we have the expected post-*tr-* masc. *-o* agreeing with the masc. gender of *libro*, and this is so even if the 1pl. possessor in (102) is entirely female. At the same time, (103)/(104) indicate that adding in agreement in gender and number with a female *nues-* is not allowed.

³⁰Cf. Postal (1969); for me, though, the deviance of these two text examples is appreciably greater than that of:

i) (?) Most Nixon-haters have never forgiven him for his behavior.

³¹If the absence of this *o-* is silence, rather than complete absence, an important question arises as to its exact position.

As for a possible account for this impossible agreement, let me focus on the plural -s that follows the -a- in (103)/(104), insofar as there is some degree of similarity between this Spanish restriction and one found in English possessives:

(105) Do you know that kid's mother?

(106) *Do you know those kids's mother?

Plural -s on the possessor cannot readily cooccur with possessive 's. That this is not simply an effect due to adjacency between -s and 's is shown by examples like those in Zwicky (1969):

(107) The Queen of England's favorite castle is not far from here.

(108) *The Queens of England's favorite castle is not far from here.

Although the match is not perfect, the resemblance between (103)/(104) and (106)/(108), both of which involve a plural -s within a possessive Spec, is striking, and gives comfort to the idea that the unacceptability of (103)/(104) will turn out to be amenable to a principled explanation.

13. Interpretation.

Let us return to the fact that Spanish, in non-clitic position, has:

(109) Juan habla de nos*(otros). ('J speaks of us others')

with *otros* obligatory. The question, what underlies that obligatoriness?, has two components. One is comparative; why is *otros* ('others') obligatory in Spanish, optional in French and Italian, and hardly possible at all in English? I don't know.

The other component could be phrased as the question, why should any language require a counterpart of *other* to supplement a first person plural pronoun? To this component question, I do see a possible answer, namely:

(110) All languages are like Spanish in this respect.

with (110) to be interpreted in a familiar way; if a given language in a given environment doesn't visibly show a counterpart of *other* with *we/us*, then there must be a silent counterpart present.

Of course we now need to ask why the language faculty would have the property that (110) holds. A possible answer to this question is that *other* is, in all languages, necessary for the interpretation of *we/us* (which amounts to saying that *otros* in (109) is not at all an expletive).

Pursuing this line of thought, we reach the proposal that the way to understand Spanish *nosotros* (and similarly for all other languages) is as a reduced relative, and more specifically as (using English words):³²

(111) we who are other than X

Transposing back to Spanish, and using capitals for silent elements, we have, for (109):

(112) Juan habla de nos WHO ARE otros THAN X

(in which the -s of *otros* is a number agreement morpheme, agreeing with the plurality of *nos*).

³²I leave open the question of when exactly *other* can be accompanied by an overt *than*-phrase. For example in English we have:

i) Other than Mary, we have nobody to turn to.

ii) Your other papers (*?than this one) are even better.

iii) Otherwise (*than that), we'll be late.

If, in (111) and (112), X = 'you', then we have what's called the 'exclusive' interpretation of first person plural. If, in (111) and (112), X does not include 'you', then we have the 'inclusive' interpretation of first person plural. (As is well-known, various languages,³³ though neither English nor Spanish, have a visible distinction between these two subtypes of first person plural.)

14. A point about features.

To be noted is the fact that the proposal of (111)/(112) makes the use of the features +/- exclusive or +/-inclusive superfluous. These features, in essence shorthand for '+/- exclusive/inclusive of *you*', are suspect by virtue of their complexity, as well as by virtue of their redundancy, insofar as they duplicate in feature form the otherwise existing syntactic structures of (111)/(112).³⁴

15. *n-* vs. *m-*

A second, rather different, point about features has to do with the *n-* of Spanish *nos* ('us'), *nuestro* ('our') et al. This *n-* is readily thought of as 1st person plural. However, if we take the plurality associated with *nos* or *nuestro* to be associated solely with its -s, as I have done above, it looks like we can take *n-* to be just first person. But that leaves us with the question how to distinguish *n-* from the *m-* of *me* and of various other 1sg. forms in the languages under discussion.

The answer, I think, depends on a partial revision of Decompositionality as in (11), repeated here:

(113) UG imposes a maximum of one (interpretable) syntactic feature per lexical item.

By (113), *n-* cannot be both first person and plural. The plurality associated with *n-* is obligatorily associated with a distinct morpheme, here -s.

In effect, while (113) forbids a given morpheme (cf. note 7) from having two syntactic features, it must now be understood as follows:³⁵

(114) A given morpheme can have only one syntactic feature, but it may in addition be obligatorily associated with a second syntactic feature if that second feature is found in another morpheme that is local to the given one.

In the cases at hand, *n-* itself is first person, but locally associated (obligatorily) with the plurality of -s. (The strongest version of locality here would have *n-* and -s externally merged with each other, and then separated from each other in the course of the derivation.)

From this perspective, *n-* and *m-* are both first person; they differ in that only *n-* is associated, in the sense of (114), with another feature, plurality.

This asymmetry between *n-* and *m-* has a striking reflex across Romance languages and dialects, in that *m-* can sometimes appear in an overall first person plural context,

³³For example, Tokelauan - cf. Hovdhaugen et al. (1989).

³⁴For general skepticism about syntactic features, as opposed to what he takes to be morphological features, see McCawley (1975, sect. 2.3.1).

³⁵The proposal in Kayne (2005a) concerning English *few* would now be partially recast as having *few* interpreted only as *little/small*, but as being in addition obligatorily associated with a local instance of *number/NUMBER*.

whereas *n-*, as far as I can see, is never found in an overall first person singular context.

As an example of *m-* in a first person plural context, there's Milanese,³⁶ in which the following is possible:

(115) La vegnarà a toeumm. ('she will-come to get-me' = 'She will come to get us') in which the *m-* morpheme in question is a post-infinitival object clitic. In fact, as far as I can see, the only such examples in which an *m-* morpheme appears to be interpreted as plural involve clitics, i.e. there appear to be no comparable examples in which the *m-* morpheme at issue would be a non-clitic.

An account of this clitic vs. non-clitic asymmetry is suggested by another Milanese example:

(116) El me ved nun. ('he me sees us' = 'He sees us')

In this example, object clitic *m-* cooccurs in doubling fashion with an object non-clitic that contains *n-*. Which leads to the following proposal:

(117) Apparent instances of *m-* as 1pl. are invariably mediated by the presence of a non-clitic double in *n-*.

This double is pronounced in (116) and silent in (115). Something quite similar is, I think, found in Italian and Spanish first person plural verb forms, e.g.:

(118) Parliamo con Gianni. (Italian 'we-speak with G')

(119) Hablamos con Juan. ('Spanish - same')

The agreement ending of these verb forms contains *-m-*, yet the interpretation is 1pl. In the present spirit, these sentences must contain a silent 1pl. subject, which can also be pronounced, with *n-* thereby made visible, as in:

(120) Noi parliamo con Gianni. (Italian 'we speak with G')

(121) Nosotros hablamos con Juan. ('Spanish - same')

The presence of *m-* in 1pl. contexts is found, then, with object clitic *m-* and with agreement suffix *-m-*, but never, it seems, with non-clitic *m-*. As an example, we can take:

(122) Gianni parla di me. ('Italian - G speaks of me')

Here, a 1pl. interpretation is not available. The reason is almost certainly that doubling of the required sort, while available with one clitic and one non-clitic, as in (116), is never available with two non-clitics.³⁷

The kind of doubling seen straightforwardly in (116) and in (120)/(121), with clitic or agreement *m-* doubling non-clitic *n-* (more exactly, a non-clitic pronoun containing *n-*), appears not to be reversible, in the sense that there appear to be no cases of clitic or agreement *n-* doubling non-clitic *m-*. Such a case would (using French morphemes) look like the following, modeled (in reverse) on (116):

(123) *Il nous voit moi. ('he us sees me')

The reason for the cross-Romance unacceptability of (123) may be as follows. In (116) *nun*, by virtue of its *n-* being associated with plural, adds plurality to the overall

³⁶Cf. Nicoli (1983, 142, 146, 150, 358), and similarly for the dialects studied by Lura (1990, 160) and Spiess (1976, 206). The double *mm* of *toeumm* in the text example is an orthographic convention indicating a preceding short vowel (cf. Nicoli, p. 49).

³⁷Future work will need to determine how the type of doubling found with Cinque's (1977; 1990) 'hanging topics' fits in here.

first person interpretation, but the parallel-positioned *moi* of (123) has no comparable way of subtracting the plurality imposed by *nous*. Consequently, there is no way in which (123) can have a 1sg. interpretation.

However, it is also the case that (123) cannot in French have a 1pl. interpretation. Nor have I ever come across such an example elsewhere in Romance with a 1pl. interpretation. Possibly, the total exclusion of (123), whether with a 1sg. or with a 1pl. interpretation, can be seen as a single fact.

16. Big DPs.

To see how such a unified approach to (123) would work, we need to briefly digress to the more general question of pronominal doubling of the sort under discussion, and to an idea from Kayne (1972, 90), to the effect that the clitic pronoun and its non-clitic double start out as the only two parts of a larger constituent that would now be called a ‘big DP’, with the clitic pronoun being lower in the structure than its non-clitic double.³⁸

For (116), this would yield [*nun me*], which, extended to (120)/(121), would then yield [*noi/nosotros -m-*]. Each of these constituents would subsequently be split apart in the course of the derivation.

As for the impossibility of (123), it would now need to be the case that there can be no [*moi nous*], with *moi* higher in the structure. This restriction could then be taken to align with Arregi’s (2025) proposal that “A plural shell can have a singular core, but a singular shell cannot have a plural core.”, with ‘shell’ corresponding to ‘higher’ and ‘core’ to ‘lower’. For Arregi, this is in turn a consequence of the more general requirement that the phi-features of the core be a subset of the phi-features of the shell, combined with the plausible idea that plural is marked and singular not.³⁹ (Whether or not this prohibition against the phi-features of the shell being a proper subset of the phi-features of the core can be unified with Condition C effects remains to be determined.)

17. A related instance of doubling.

The doubling seen in (116) and in (120)/(121) has a counterpart with subject clitics in various French dialects. In French, the 1sg. subject clitic is *je*, as in:⁴⁰

(124) *Je vais à Paris.* (‘I go to P’)

The form of the verb is distinct from that occurring with the 1pl. subject clitic *nous*:

(125) *Nous allons à Paris.* (‘we go to P’)

³⁸Cf. also Uriagereka (1995) and Kayne (2002; 2009).

³⁹This asymmetry between plural and singular will need to be reconciled with Kouneli (2019) on singulatives in Kipsigis.

The discrepancy in number under discussion seems not to have any counterpart with person, i.e. there seems to be no instance of doubling in which the two ‘pieces’ differ from one another in person; this would seem to support Shlonsky’s (1989) sharp separation of person from number, along with the idea that number, but not person, is privative - cf. Harley and Ritter (2002).

⁴⁰I leave open here the question of how best to understand the *j-* of *je* vs. the *m-* of all the other 1sg. forms.

In the various dialects in question, the counterpart of *je* can cooccur with the counterpart of the *-ons* agreement ending of (125),⁴¹ as in, for example, the dialect described by Fougeu-Fontaine (1986, 52):⁴²

(126) J em ('I love')

(127) J emo ('1 love-1 pl.' = 'We love')

In the spirit of the proposals made above for (116) and (120)/(121), example (127) will be taken to have *j* doubled within a 'big DP' by a higher *-o* (accompanied in all likelihood by a silent N).

18. *v-* vs. *t-*.

The discussion above of first person *n-* vs. *m-* leads one to wonder about second person plural *v-* and second person singular (familiar) *t-*, which are widespread across Romance. For *n-* and *m-*, we had the examples in (120)/(121), repeated here:

(128) Noi parliamo con Gianni. (Italian 'we speak with G')

(129) Nosotros hablamos con Juan. ('Spanish - same')

in which the subject pronoun containing 1pl. *n-* is doubled by 1sg. *m-*. A plausibly parallel Italian second person example is:

(130) Voi parlate con Gianni. ('you(pl.) speak with G')

in which the subject pronoun containing *v-* could be taken to be doubled by *t-*.

A second case in which 2sg. *t-* is related to plural is found in Walloon:⁴³

(131) tè-s-ôtes ('your-others')

in which a possessive form of 2sg. occurs,⁴⁴ with an overall interpretation of a plurality of familiar addressees.

On the other hand, I haven't noticed any second person cases in Romance parallel to (116), in which an object clitic with *m-* was paired with a non-clitic with *n-*. If such exist, they would look like the following (using French words):

(132) *Ils te voient vous. ('they you(sg.) see you(plural)')

Whether or not such second person examples are possible bears on the question of how parallel first and second person are to each other.

19. Spanish *vos*

Collins and Ordóñez (2021) and Collins and Kayne (2023) follow Harris (1998) and Embick (2015) in taking Latin American Spanish to completely lack the 2pl. *v-* of non-clitic *vosotros* and possessive *vuestro*. While this seems to be correct for the two forms

⁴¹Cf. Remacle (1952, 217).

The *-n-* of the 1pl. *-ons* is very likely the *n-* of *nuestro*, *nosotros* et al.

⁴²Long-term thanks are due here to Yves-Charles Morin for having provided me with access to his remarkable French dialect library.

Other such dialect examples can be found in Butler (1962, 39, 42), Chauveau (1984, 190), Ditchy (1977, 21), Gesner (1979, 17), Hervé (1973, 51), Maze (1969, 41, 66, 83, 85) (who notes that *je* cannot invert and that *nous* can appear with inversion), Rouffiange (1983, 115), Vey (1978, 186), Villefranche (1978, 24), Féral (1986, 68, 73-5), Hauchard (1994, 137), and Hull (1988).

⁴³As discussed by Remacle (1952, 233, 243-5).

⁴⁴The possessive here may be related to that of (British) English *in their thousands*.

mentioned, (some) Latin American Spanish has, as noted by Butt and Benjamin (1994, sect. 11.3), the use of *vos* as second person singular, which in Carolina Fraga's (p.c.) Argentinian Spanish can occur as subject pronoun or as the object of a preposition.

Of interest to the present paper is the contrast, within Latin American Spanish, between (the sometimes possible) *vos* and (the never possible) *vosotros*, with the reason presumably being that *otros* cannot be added to a singular pronoun (Latin American *vos*) in the way that it can be added to a plural pronoun (as in *nosotros* and as in peninsular Spanish *vosotros*).

As for the question why *otros* cannot be added to singular *vos*, the answer must be related to the discussion of (77)-(79) above concerning the contrast between plural *we linguists* and the impossible singular **I linguist*, with many details still to be filled in and with my guess being that it will also depend on the assumption that *otros* can never be a true expletive (i.e. *otros* always makes some interpretive contribution).⁴⁵

As Butt and Benjamin (1994, sect. 11.3) note, the possessive form for Latin American singular *vos* is actually *tu(s)* and the corresponding object clitic form *te*, both with *t*- rather than with *v*-.⁴⁶ Possibly, the generalization is that singular forms in *v*- are never possible in clitic(-like) positions (possessive, object clitic), but only in non-clitic positions (subject, object of P).

Possibly, in turn, this generalization is related to a fact about Condition B-like/overlapping reference effects in Italian that was pointed out to me by Luigi Burzio (p.c.), namely that they are sharper with clitics than with non-clitics, e.g.:

(133) ?Consideriamo me intelligente. ('we-consider me intelligent')

(134) *Mi consideriamo intelligente. ('me we-consider intelligent')

The proposal made for these facts in (the more extended discussion in) Kayne (2002, sect. 9) was in effect that (133) could to some extent avoid a violation by virtue of having the pronoun *me* accompanied by a silent element that would protect it from that violation in the way that *self* protects *him* in:

(135) John considers him*(self) intelligent.

In (134), on the other hand, the clitic status of *mi* disallows the presence of such a protective silent element.

Transposed to the question of *vos*, this amounts to the claim that singular *vos* is possible only if accompanied by a silent element of the sort that accompanies *me* in (133). Possibly (again), this silent element will, in a way yet to be determined, play a

⁴⁵For general skepticism about expletives, see Kayne (2023).

⁴⁶The text proposal that follows constitutes an attempt to go well beyond any invocation of 'suppletion' - cf. Kayne (2024b).

role in allowing the apparent plurality of the -s of *vos* not to override the overall singularity of *vos*.⁴⁷

20. Conclusion.

Other is part of Spanish *nosotros*. *Other* may well always be part of first person plural, in a way that makes the features +/-exclusive/inclusive superfluous. Part of *other* is part of Spanish *nuestro*. Progress can be made toward an understanding of what is part of what. The intricate properties of the Romance person morphemes *n-*, *m-*, *v-* and *t-* are compatible with Decompositionality, suitably interpreted.

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⁴⁷One may want to bring in here the existence of singular *y'all* in (some) Southern American English - cf. Hyman (2006).

There is also the fact, brought to my attention by Carolina Fraga (p.c.), that some speakers can drop the -s of *vos*, but only in vocatives. This restriction to vocatives recalls, for my English:

- i) Hey, you two! What do you think you're doing?
- ii) *?Hey, the two of you! What do you think you're doing?

though why this similarity holds remains to be determined; for relevant discussion, see, e.g., Moro (2013) and Slocum (2016).

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